through their own statutes. An adult found begging on the streets can be arrested without warrant and produced before a magistrate. If found to be part of an organised syndicate, they can be sent to a certified institution for detention, which can last from a few months to three years, or be penalised and let off with a warning. If found needy, they are shifted to shelter homes—Ahmedabad has 35 of them.

A child follows a separate track. They must be produced before a district child welfare committee (CWC) within 24 hours as a "child in need of care and protection", which triggers a social investigation. That inquiry ends in restoration to the family, placement in a child care home, or a sponsorship and school-enrolment order. An adult who put a child on the street faces prosecution under the Juvenile Justice Act. Whether the rescued child stays in school or in a safe environment or returns to the streets—perhaps in a new city—is a tricky question to which there are no clear answers.

Of the 150 children picked up in June, 104 were presented before the CWC. Of these, 100 were accompanied by parents and restored to their custody with a warning to not return to begging; four girls were sent to care homes. The state claims 23 were enrolled in local government schools. Details about the remaining 85 'rescued' children were not made available. Activists working in this domain for decades say rehabilitation claims are overstated since most street people have no documents, give inconsistent names, and are invariably released without any record trail.

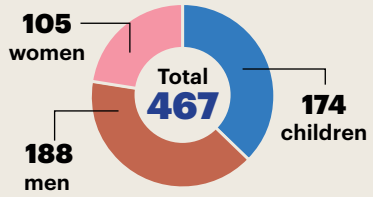
The AHTU, meanwhile, confronts another side to this. Over the past two years, it has separately rescued 276 children, including a 15-day old infant. The trail led to an inter-state trafficking racket—a bust that revealed how the crime feeds on poverty. The grimmest finding: village sarpanches in Rajasthan and Madhya Pradesh were found to be acting as brokers. The syndicate approaches sarpanches to identify families in extreme poverty; the sarpanch takes a cut of the advance paid to parents, plus around 20 per cent of the children's daily earnings thereafter. Deployment is mapped by revenue potential, with religious places generating the highest collections, followed by traffic intersections, hospitals and shopping malls. Some parents are said to have agreed to send children after being promised an income.

HOMELESS IN AHMEDABAD

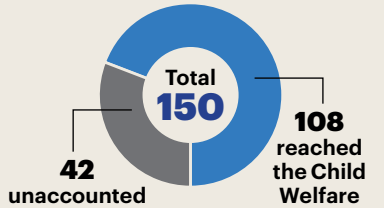
11,293
According to Census 2011

100,000
Estimate by Housing and Land Rights Network, counting street-dwellers, daily-wage labourers with no housing, transitory migrants. No estimate of those purely involved in begging.

PEOPLE PICKED UP SINCE APRIL 2026



CHILDREN PICKED UP IN A JUNE DRIVE



126
Begging spots identified

Inter-state mafias at work, procuring children from poor families in Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh for begging

Takeaways

- **Ahmedabad tries to clean its streets ahead of CWG 2030, Olympic bids**
- **Anti-begging drive sees 467 'rescued'; norms on rehabilitation are fuzzy**
- **Police, as part of drive, find sarpanches in MP, Rajasthan aid trafficking**

'WON'T LOOK GOOD'

Says Himala Joshi, ACP and AHTU in-charge, "We have also found that the homeless and begging families living under flyovers are seasonal migrants who come looking for work, but take to begging instead simply because it becomes remunerative," she says. Both Shah and Joshi claim they have helped equip the rescued beggars with documentation like Aadhaar cards to enable them to avail government schemes and enrol their children in state schools.

Rajesh Bhat, convenor of the voluntary organisations-citizens' network Child Rights Collective Gujarat, feels the drives fail on three counts. The veteran child rights activist says the collective has learnt that the state government was advised that beggars and homeless people "won't look good" in a city hosting such an international event. "The motive itself is suspect—a kneejerk reaction to make the streets 'look good', rather than an empathetic effort to rehabilitate children on the street or rehabilitate destitute families," he says. "Consequently, the method is not scientific." No NGO working on long-term rehabilitation was brought into the operation, as in earlier drives. Many of the rescuees may simply fall through the sieve, back to the anonymity of the streets. ■